

LOCOMOTIF | S. PRASANNARAJAN

Gandhis Apart

Hymns to Our Lady of Deliverance are flowing out of the styluses of professional panygyrists of the Family and sundry mythmakers from the media. All they needed for the sudden vindication of their faith was the passing of the Women's Reservation Bill in the Upper House. A historic moment in the progressive politics of the subcontinent, they said, and the heartwarming sight of the Left-Right incompatibilities being swept aside by the emotional solidarity of Sisters Triumphant only added to the generosity of the Indian democracy. There would have been no such Bill without the visionary leadership of Sonia Gandhi, the hymn writers kept reminding us. After all, we continue to be told, those male chauvinists from the infernal depths of our democracy will never allow gender justice, for they are the ruthless practitioners of the politics of entitlement. Now, we have at last got a leader with iron in her soul, and let us canonise her as the new Mrs G, who is better and brighter than the original. Or, so read the hymns. First, take the Bill, which is nothing but what we may call pop con, kitschy politics' trick on the mass mind. This Bill, the latest in the world's most elastic republic of quotas, contributes only to the gender ghettoisation of our politics. Reservation is a restriction. It is the repudiation of freedom. In the quota country, women are now a category. This Bill goes against the spirit of the 21st century India where the state should not be the arbiter on the choices, political or otherwise, of its citizens, irrespective of their sex.

The Bill doesn't mark the birth of the new Mrs G either. To say Sonia is proving to be better than her mother-in-law in political smarts is to ignore the historical context in which Indira asserted her leadership. She didn't really inherit the party as Sonia did.

When she began, it was not a party of India-is-Indira sycophants; it was home to some well entrenched pachyderms who wanted to play puppet masters. Indira had to first outsmart the vulpine old men of the Syndicate before she could enter into an emotional covenant with her country as Mother India. Like other great leaders, she was too multi-dimensional to be straitjacketed: her flaws were matched by her strengths; her paranoia by her power; her charisma by her opacity; her benevolence by her ruthlessness. Her finest as well as her worst moments were born out of a deeper commitment to an idea of India. And she was out there, amidst the people, in permanent conversation with the nation. Sonia, in her starched cotton, may mime the original but she, a leader born out of the collective desperation of a party that has mortgaged its mind to the Family, is nowhere nearer.



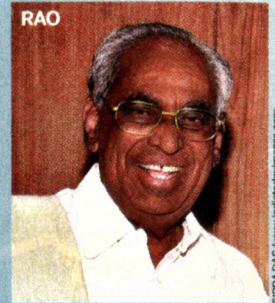
TO SAY SONIA IS PROVING TO BE BETTER THAN HER MOTHER-IN-LAW IN POLITICAL SMARTS IS TO IGNORE THE HISTORICAL CONTEXT IN WHICH INDIRA ASSERTED HER LEADERSHIP.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Fomer Andhra Pradesh deputy chief minister and senior Congress leader **Koneru Ranga Rao**. A three-time MLA, he served as the deputy chief minister from 1989 to 1994.



DIED: Marathi poet and Jnanpith laureate **Govind Vinayak Karandikar**, 92. Informally called 'Vinda', he was widely regarded as the most experimental of all Marathi poets. Among other works, he translated Aristotle's poetry into Marathi.

APPOINTED: **Jaya Singh Chauhan** as the first-ever woman IG of Indian Railways. She was serving as DIG, Railway Protection Force Academy, Lucknow.

APPOINTED: **M. K. Lokesh** as the next ambassador of India to the United Arab Emirates. He will succeed Tamiz Ahmad.

AWARDED: The 2008 Dada Saheb Phalke Award to cinematographer **V.K. Murthy**. He will be presented the award at the 56th National Film Awards function on March 19.

